

The Ledger of Small Hours

It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking thirteen. The narrator's voice—dry, precise, faintly amused—carried the whole weight of the thing. “One must imagine Sisyphus happy,” he wrote, and the phrase has never quite recovered from the burden of being quoted at parties.

Consider the naïve café owner in Señor Márquez's story: he believed a ledger could hold a life. He kept it in a drawer beneath the till, and every evening he entered the day's small sums in a hand that grew steadily less legible as the years went on.

A second movement

This paragraph is deliberately long so that the extractor has to reassemble a good many justified lines into a single flowing block of prose, without inserting the spurious line breaks that make most naive PDF text extraction useless for actual reading. Justification stretches the inter-word spacing unevenly from line to line, which is precisely what tends to confuse a naive reader of the content stream.

THE LEDGER OF SMALL HOURS

The ledger, at the end, held nothing but numbers. That was the joke, and he was too tired to laugh at it.

Short closing line.